

# The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance Teacher of the Year:

Dance Teacher of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

## Judges will consider:

- Quality and clarity of teaching practice
- Ability to motivate, inspire, and support students
- Awareness of different learning needs and pathways
- Commitment to student wellbeing and safe practice
- Evidence of professional integrity and reliability
- Ongoing professional development
- Positive impact within their school or community
- Commitment to inclusive and respectful teaching practice that supports a diverse range of students
- A clear case for why this teacher stands out this year

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1. What makes you an exceptional teacher? \*

I believe that the best teaching begins with seeing the person before the dancer.

I hold high expectations for my students and am passionate about developing technically strong, confident, creative dancers. However, I never believe that technical excellence should come at the expense of a child's wellbeing, individuality, or sense of self. My teaching is rooted in the belief that these things are not competing priorities: when a student feels safe, understood, and valued, they are more able to take risks, overcome challenges, and reach their potential.

I teach every class at Eleanor Clark Dance Company myself, allowing me to build genuine, consistent relationships with every student. I take time to understand how each dancer learns, what motivates them, where they struggle, and what they need from me. I adapt my teaching to different learning styles, personalities, abilities, and neurodiverse needs, rather than expecting every child to learn in the same way.

I believe in teaching with both precision and compassion. I want my students to understand why they are doing something, not simply copy a movement. I encourage questions, celebrate progress, and create an environment where mistakes are treated as part of learning rather than something to fear. I challenge students to work hard while ensuring they know that their worth is never dependent on their performance.

My students pursue very different goals, from dancing purely for joy and confidence to achieving examination success, competing, performing on industry platforms, and progressing towards vocational training. I am equally invested in every journey, because every student's version of success matters.

The impact of this approach has been reflected in the feedback I receive from families. One parent described my dedication to dance and my pupils as "beyond commitment - it is a way of life", while another shared that "from the very beginning, Eleanor has shown incredible support, warmth, and genuine care for each student." These words mean a great deal to me because they reflect the kind of teacher I strive to be every day.

Above all, I want every student who enters my classroom to leave feeling a little more confident, capable, and proud of themselves than when they arrived. I believe that is the true responsibility, and privilege, of being a teacher.

## 2. How do you support and inspire your students? \*

I support and inspire my students by making them feel genuinely seen, believed in, and valued.

I believe that children are far more likely to grow when they feel safe enough to try. My teaching creates an environment where students can make mistakes, ask questions, take risks, and try again without fear of embarrassment or judgement. I actively celebrate effort, resilience, kindness, and personal progress alongside technical achievement.

Because I teach every class myself, I know my students as individuals. I understand their different personalities, learning styles, strengths, challenges, and ambitions, and I adapt my approach accordingly. This is particularly important when supporting neurodiverse students, who may need information communicated differently, additional processing time, or a different route to understanding a movement or concept.

I also believe inspiration comes from helping students see what is possible. I provide opportunities to perform, compete, take examinations, attend workshops, audition, and experience professional environments, while ensuring that ambition is always balanced with wellbeing. I want students to see that there are many ways to belong in the dance world and that their journey does not have to look like anyone else's.

I always strive to model the qualities I want my students to develop: kindness, resilience, curiosity, discipline, and courage. This was recognised at one of our competitions, where I received an award for kindness and supportive teaching - not only towards my own students, but towards other competitors too. I was particularly proud of this because I could see those same values reflected in my students: the way they supported others, celebrated fellow dancers, and represented ECDC with generosity and respect.

The words I receive from my students and their families continually remind me why this matters. One parent described my approach as "dedication to nurturing each dancer's unique journey", while another shared that their daughter "has grown in confidence so much" and that my passion for dance "makes X want to be the very best she can be." They described me as "a wonderful role model" for their child. For me, this captures exactly what I hope to inspire: not perfection, but the desire to grow, to believe in yourself, and to become the very best version of yourself.

Most importantly, I want my students to know that I believe in them. Whether their goal is to perform professionally or simply to walk into class feeling a little more confident than they did the week before, I want every child to feel that their journey matters.

My aim is not simply to create better dancers. It is to help young people discover what they are capable of - and to give them the confidence to believe it for themselves.

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### 3. How do you continue to develop professionally? \*

Being a good teacher means never believing you have finished learning. My professional development is shaped by both formal training and a commitment to continually reflecting on and improving my practice. I hold ISTD DDE qualifications in Ballet, Modern, and Tap, achieving over 90% in all three exams, alongside a 1st Class BA (Hons) Theatre degree from Guildford School of Acting and diplomas in Musical Theatre, SEND, Child Psychology, and Eating Disorder Understanding and Awareness.

I am currently studying the Certificate in Dancer's Injury Prevention and Wellbeing with the Dance Teacher Training Academy, further developing my understanding of how to support young dancers both physically and emotionally. I am committed to continually learning and improving because my greatest motivation is to be the best teacher I can possibly be for my students.

My learning around SEND and neurodiversity has been particularly important in shaping my teaching. I hold Level 2, 3, and 4 qualifications in Special Educational Needs, and I actively apply this knowledge in the studio, adapting communication, structure, and teaching methods to ensure students can access high-quality training in ways that work for them.

I also continue to develop through the students I teach. Every dancer provides an opportunity to reflect: Did they understand? Did I communicate that effectively? Could I have explained it differently? What does this particular student need from me next? I regularly evaluate my teaching and adapt my approach rather than relying on a single method.

Running ECDC has also developed my professional practice far beyond the classroom. As a founder-led school, I have built and managed the organisation from the ground up, developing systems, safeguarding procedures, pastoral practice, performance opportunities, examination pathways, and vocational progression routes.

Ultimately, I believe professional development is not simply about collecting qualifications (though I do love to study!). It is about remaining curious, reflective, and willing to change when something can be done better. My responsibility is to keep learning so that I can continue to give my students the very best of what I know.

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#### 4. What impact have you had in the last year? \*

Over the last year, my greatest impact has been creating a learning environment where children can thrive both as dancers and as people.

Since founding Eleanor Clark Dance Company in June 2025, I have grown the school from 10 classes across two days to 29 classes across four days, with enrolment trebling between July 2025 and March 2026. I have taught every class throughout this growth, meaning that the relationships and "more than movement" culture at the heart of ECDC have remained consistent as the school has expanded.

My students have achieved 100% Distinctions and High Merits in ISTD examinations, while ECDC has been named Overall Most Outstanding Dance School and Overall Winner on five occasions across Regional Heats and National Finals in 2026. Students have performed at MOVE IT and accessed scholarships and opportunities with leading vocational institutions including Laine Theatre Arts, Performers College, Miskin Theatre, and PUSH.

However, the impact I am most proud of cannot be measured in trophies or certificates.

Parents have described ECDC as their child's "happy place" and a "safe place and trusted person". One parent shared that, during one of the most difficult times in their lives while undergoing treatment for cancer, I became "not just a teacher, but a safe place and trusted person" for their child. They described the compassion, consistency, and support their child received as providing "a sense of normalcy and emotional security that made an immeasurable difference."

This means more to me than any award because they demonstrate the impact a teacher can have far beyond technique.

I am also proud of the impact of creating a genuinely inclusive environment. Students with different abilities, learning styles, personalities, and aspirations are welcomed and supported, with neurodiversity actively understood and embraced.

At ECDC's first-ever regional competition, we were recognised not only for our students' performances, but for the kindness and generosity they showed towards others. Then at another competition later in the year, I was personally honoured with a Host Award for Kindness and Supportive Teaching. To me, the significance of these two moments lies in the fact that the values I try to model as a teacher are being reflected both in my own teaching and in the young people I am helping to shape. I want my students to leave ECDC as technically capable dancers, but also as kind, resilient, supportive, and confident young people - and seeing those values recognised beyond our own studio was incredibly meaningful.

My impact this year has been about building something that reaches beyond the studio - a community where children feel they belong, families feel supported, and young people are given the confidence to believe in themselves. I have created a space that challenges the traditional idea of what dance training should be: a model where technical excellence and emotional wellbeing are equal priorities, not competing values.

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## 5. Why should you be recognised now? \*

I believe I should be recognised now because the last year has been about far more than building a successful dance school. It has been about finding myself again through dance, and then using what I found to help other young people find confidence, belonging, and joy too.

A year ago, I was at one of the lowest points of my life, trying to find my way forward and questioning where I belonged within the dance world. I could have walked away. Instead, I chose to build something new.

Eleanor Clark Dance Company became my light. I poured everything I had into creating the kind of dance environment I had always wanted to exist: one where children could work hard, dream big, and achieve extraordinary things without sacrificing their wellbeing, individuality, or sense of self.

Since founding ECDC in June 2025, I have grown the school in number, while continuing to personally teach every class and protect the individual relationships that define my practice. My students have achieved exceptional examination results, significant competitive success, and progressed towards leading vocational training opportunities.

But the reason I believe I should be recognised now is not simply because of what my students have achieved. It is because of what they have become - and what they have helped me become too.

One student wrote: "The environment you have created is incredible. I have felt so welcomed by everyone but especially you! You should be so incredibly proud of yourself."

Another said: "Thank you for inspiring me and for making me fall in love with dance. Thank you for teaching me not only how to become a better dancer, but for showing me what it truly means to be a nice person. I'll never forget what you've done for me."

These words remind me that teaching is about so much more than delivering a class. It is about the moments when a child finds their confidence again. When a dancer returns after injury and discovers that they still belong. When a young person learns that kindness and ambition can exist together. When a child who once doubted themselves begins to believe they are capable of more.

I founded ECDC because I wanted to create the safe, joyful, nurturing space that I had needed myself. The most extraordinary part of this journey has been realising that, while I thought I was building a place to help others, I was also rebuilding myself.

I believe I should be recognised now because I am not simply teaching steps. I am helping young people discover their own potential, while creating a culture where they feel safe enough to reach it.

This year has shown me that one teacher, with a clear vision and an unwavering commitment to her students, can make a meaningful difference. I would be incredibly proud for that work to be recognised through Dance Teacher of the Year - not simply for what I have achieved, but for the young people I have had the privilege of helping to grow.

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